

Unit II: Harmony in the Self and Human Relationships

1. Understanding the Self and the Body

Conceptual Meaning

A human being is a **coexistence of two entities**:

1. **The Self (Conscious Entity / “I”)** – the inner being, which feels, thinks, analyzes, and decides. It is non-material, conscious, and continuous.
2. **The Body (Material Entity)** – the physical, tangible structure made up of cells and matter, which is perishable and temporary.

The **Self** uses the **Body** as an instrument to express itself and interact with the external world — just as a driver uses a vehicle to move around.

However, while the driver (Self) has consciousness and purpose, the vehicle (Body) has no awareness on its own.

Interpretation

- The **Body** needs food, rest, exercise, and medical care.
- The **Self** needs peace, happiness, love, respect, and understanding.

Confusing the needs of the body for those of the self leads to imbalance — material abundance but emotional emptiness.

True well-being arises when both are nurtured harmoniously.

For instance, a person may eat fine food (physical satisfaction) but still feel restless, lonely, or anxious (psychological dissatisfaction).

Hence, harmony requires understanding both entities and addressing their distinct needs appropriately.

Traditional, Religious, and Contemporary Insights

- **Indian Philosophy:**
The *Bhagavad Gita* (2:22) teaches: “*As a man sheds worn-out garments and puts on new*

ones, so the soul (Self) casts off the body and enters another.”

This highlights that the Self (Atman) is eternal, while the body is perishable.

- **Islamic Perspective:**

The Quran explains that man is made from *clay* (body) and *spirit* (Ruh). The spirit gives life and awareness; the body gives form and function.

- **Buddhism:**

Consciousness (*Vijnana*) coexists with form (*Rupa*); balance between them through mindfulness ensures peace.

- **Modern Psychology:**

Carl Jung differentiates between the *ego-self* (material identity) and the *true self* (spiritual essence).

Health science today recognizes the **mind–body connection**: emotional imbalance manifests as physical illness.

Classroom Reflection

Ask students: “Do we spend more time taking care of our body or our mind?”

Guide them to realize that while physical health is visible, mental harmony is equally — if not more — important.

2. Happiness and Right Understanding

Definition

Happiness is a continuous state of inner contentment, harmony, and satisfaction within oneself.

Right Understanding refers to the correct knowledge of one’s own existence, purpose, and relationship with others and nature.

Happiness is not the same as pleasure.

- *Pleasure* is short-term and sensory (e.g., good food, entertainment).
 - *Happiness* is long-term and arises from inner clarity and positive relationships.
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Interpretation

Most people mistakenly chase happiness through external possessions — wealth, fame, or status — yet find themselves restless or unfulfilled.

This is because happiness cannot be “purchased”; it is **experienced** when the self is in harmony with its thoughts, feelings, and actions.

Right understanding corrects our perception of what truly brings happiness:

- From **possession to purpose**,
 - From **competition to cooperation**, and
 - From **self-centeredness to self-realization**.
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Traditional and Religious Examples

- **Hindu Philosophy:**
The concept of *Santosha* (contentment) in *Yoga Sutras* highlights that happiness comes not from fulfilling every desire but from reducing unnecessary desires.
Lord Krishna teaches Arjuna to act without attachment — *Nishkama Karma* — as the key to peace.
 - **Islam:**
Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) said, “*True wealth is not in possessions but in contentment of the soul.*”
Islam links happiness to inner purity and gratitude (*Shukr*).
 - **Buddhism:**
The Middle Path avoids extremes of indulgence and deprivation, promoting balanced living and awareness.
 - **Contemporary Example:**
Successful industrialists like Ratan Tata or Azim Premji find fulfillment through philanthropy — transforming personal success into social welfare.
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Teaching Reflection

Ask:

“When you help someone selflessly, how do you feel compared to when you buy something new?”

Students will discover that inner satisfaction outlasts material pleasure.

3. Feelings, Thoughts, and Behavior

Conceptual Understanding

Human behavior is not random — it flows from a deep internal process comprising:

1. **Feelings (Values)** – what we emotionally hold as important.

2. **Thoughts (Beliefs)** – how we reason based on those feelings.
 3. **Behavior (Actions)** – how we express those thoughts in real life.
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Interpretation

When our **feelings, thoughts, and behavior** are aligned, we experience integrity, peace, and clarity.

Disharmony among them causes confusion and conflict.

Example:

If a person values honesty (feeling), believes truth builds trust (thought), and speaks truthfully (behavior) — there is inner harmony.

But if they lie to gain advantage, guilt and stress arise — an internal conflict between value and action.

Traditional and Religious Wisdom

- **Hindu Thought:**
The ideal of *Manasa-Vacha-Karmana Ekata* — unity of thought, speech, and action — defines integrity.
 - **Islam:**
Niyyah (intention) must be pure; without right intention, even good acts lose moral worth.
 - **Christianity:**
“As you think in your heart, so shall you be.” (Proverbs 23:7) — showing that action originates in thought.
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Contemporary Insight

Modern psychology calls this “**congruence**.”

People who act consistently with their beliefs exhibit mental stability and confidence; those who act against their conscience suffer anxiety and guilt.

4. Role of Values in Personal Conduct

Definition

Values are enduring principles that define what is right and desirable in human life and guide decisions toward harmony and well-being.

Interpretation

Values act as a compass for moral and ethical behavior. They are not imposed by society but discovered through reflection and self-exploration.

When values are internalized, conduct becomes self-regulated rather than fear-driven.

Core Human Values

Truth, honesty, trust, respect, compassion, responsibility, forgiveness, gratitude, and love.

Illustrative Examples

- **Traditional:**
In the *Ramayana*, Lord Rama's life exemplifies adherence to truth and duty (*Dharma*) even in hardship.
 - **Religious:**
Prophet Muhammad's honesty and reliability earned him the title *Al-Amin* (The Trustworthy).
Jesus taught forgiveness and humility as supreme virtues.
 - **Contemporary:**
Ethical leaders like Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam and Mahatma Gandhi embodied truth and simplicity, showing that integrity yields long-term respect.
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Interpretation for Students

Values determine the **quality of our relationships** and **the peace of our mind**.

Ask: *When your actions match your principles, how do you feel? When they don't, how do you feel?*

This helps them internalize that values are not imposed but naturally fulfilling.

5. Harmony in Family and Society

Definition

Harmony in family and society refers to living with mutual understanding, trust, and care so that every member experiences happiness and respect.

Interpretation

The **family** is the first laboratory of human relationships.

When family relations are governed by love, understanding, and cooperation, society naturally becomes peaceful and just.

Conversely, when family ties weaken, selfishness and conflict spread into the wider community.

Harmony at the family level thus acts as the foundation for **social harmony**.

Traditional and Religious Perspectives

- **Indian Philosophy:**
“Matru Devo Bhava, Pitru Devo Bhava” — parents are to be revered like divine beings. Joint families historically encouraged emotional security and collective well-being.
 - **Confucianism:**
The stability of society begins with harmony in the home; the five fundamental relationships guide ethical living.
 - **Islam:**
Silat al-Rahim (maintaining family bonds) is considered an act of faith and a source of blessings.
 - **Christianity:**
The Bible emphasizes family love: “Honor thy father and mother.”
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Contemporary Insight

- Nuclear families and fast lifestyles have weakened emotional bonds. Therefore, there is a renewed need to consciously practice communication, empathy, and care.
 - Family counseling, community volunteering, and social support networks are modern ways of restoring harmony.
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6. Fundamental Human Values in Relationships

(a) Trust (Vishwas)

Meaning: The conviction that the other person wants my happiness and well-being.

Interpretation: Trust eliminates fear, suspicion, and exploitation — the foundation of every healthy relationship.

Example: In education, mutual trust between teacher and student fosters genuine learning.

(b) Respect (Samman)

Meaning: Recognizing the innate worth of every human being.

Interpretation: Respect is unconditional — it is given because of humanity, not hierarchy.

Traditional: *Namaste* symbolizes “The divine in me honors the divine in you.”

Modern: Respect for diverse opinions and backgrounds in workplaces reflects maturity.

(c) Affection (Sneha)

Meaning: Emotional warmth arising from trust and respect.

Example: A teacher’s affection motivates students more than punishment or reward.

(d) Care (Poshan)

Meaning: Attending to others’ needs with sensitivity.

Example: Helping elders, volunteering in community health drives.

Interpretation: Care converts empathy into action.

(e) Guidance (Margdarshan)

Meaning: Supporting others’ growth through wisdom and experience.

Example: The Guru–Shishya tradition in India; modern mentorship programs in universities.

(f) Gratitude (Kritagyata)

Meaning: Acknowledging and appreciating help or kindness received.

Interpretation: Gratitude transforms ego into humility.

Example: Thanking parents, teachers, or even nature for their role in our life.

Religious: “Give thanks in all circumstances.” (Bible)

(g) Love (Prem)

Meaning: The total and unconditional feeling of goodwill for all beings.

Interpretation: Love integrates all values — trust, respect, care culminate in love.

Traditional: *Ahimsa Parmo Dharma* — non-violence as the highest virtue.

Religious: “God is Love.” (Christianity)

Modern: Mahatma Gandhi’s *Sarvodaya* (welfare of all) reflects universal love through service.

7. Justice and Mutual Fulfillment in Human Relationships

Definition

Justice means the recognition and fulfillment of each person’s rightful expectations, leading to **mutual happiness** and **trust**.

It is the natural outcome of relationships based on right understanding and values.

Interpretation

Justice begins at the interpersonal level before it manifests as social or legal fairness.

It requires:

1. Recognition of relationship,
2. Understanding of feelings and duties,
3. Fulfilling them sincerely, and
4. Evaluating whether mutual happiness is achieved.

When each person fulfills their role responsibly, harmony replaces conflict.

Traditional, Religious, and Modern Examples

- **Ram Rajya** in Indian thought represented social justice, equality, and welfare for all.
- **Islam:** *Adl* (justice) and *Ihsan* (benevolence) are divine commands.
- **Christianity:** “Do unto others as you would have them do unto you.”
- **Buddhism:** The Law of *Karma* ensures justice through moral consequence.

- **Modern:** Social justice movements for gender equality, human rights, or environmental sustainability all stem from the human need for fairness and mutual fulfillment.
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8. Mutual Happiness and Social Harmony – The Ultimate State

When human conduct is guided by values and right understanding:

- The **Self** experiences inner peace.
 - The **Family** functions with love, trust, and respect.
 - The **Society** progresses with justice and cooperation.
 - The **World** sustains itself through balance with nature.
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Interpretation

An individual at peace contributes to a peaceful family; peaceful families build harmonious societies, and harmonious societies sustain global peace.

Thus, personal transformation becomes the foundation of universal transformation.

Traditional and Contemporary Echo

- **Vedic Vision:** *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* — “The world is one family.”
 - **Buddhism:** Compassion toward all beings.
 - **Islam:** Brotherhood (*Ummah*) among all believers.
 - **Christianity:** Universal love and forgiveness.
 - **Modern:** The United Nations’ Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) embody the same principles of harmony among people, planet, and prosperity.
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Conclusion

Harmony in the Self and Human Relationships is the essence of human existence.

It begins with **understanding the self and the body**, grows through **right understanding and value-based living**, and blossoms in **relationships rooted in trust, respect, affection, and love**.

Justice, gratitude, and compassion sustain this harmony, leading to **mutual happiness, family unity, social well-being, and global peace**.

Education, therefore, should not merely produce skilled individuals but **value-oriented human beings** — capable of thinking deeply, acting ethically, and living harmoniously with themselves, others, and nature.